On-the-Job Skilling for Nishant

With PR snafus in hot pursuit of the JD(U) scion, his party seniors roll out a makeover

alter the approach. On July 7, Nishant carried out another surprise hospital inspection in Patna, walking through outpatient departments, interacting with patients and reviewing services.

THE RETREATING SORT

Since joining the Samrat Choudhary cabinet in May, Nishant has not gone forth so much to put himself on the front pages but that reclusive mien is being shed—albeit gradually. Has it begun to change his image? Can the JD(U) convince a sceptical Bihar public? The answer may well determine not only Nishant's political future but also that of a party preparing for life after Nitish. The JD(U) is leaving little to chance. Giving it time is fair enough. After all, it's been barely four months since Nishant entered active politics.

Samrat's government, too, has helped bolster the JD(U)'s efforts. Two days after Nishant was inducted on May 7, it appointed one of Bihar's most respected IAS officers, Kumar Ravi, as health secretary. Within bureaucratic circles, it was understood that the first-time minister was being furnished with a strong administrative anchor. Ravi was one of Nitish's trusted officers, and had served in the CM's secretariat during his tenure. On July 21, Nishant addressed the Bihar Legislative Council for the first time. The two-minute speech mostly stressed on "Pitaji's" *margdarshan* (guidance) always being there for him. The remark appears to have reassured party workers to some extent.

Takeaways

- **Nitish Kumar's son and new minister Nishant is being invested with a more proactive public persona**
- **This repackaging follows an underwhelming debut where he drew attention for his awkward manner**



ANI

SLOW AND STEADY Minister Nishant gets a garland from JD(U) partymen

THE NITISH VACUUM

Meanwhile, posters projecting Nishant as the inheritor of the Nitish legacy have appeared across Patna. At the JD(U)'s national council meeting in June, seniors described him as the natural successor. It came as no surprise. With Nitish in the Rajya Sabha and withdrawing from the day-to-day theatre of Bihar politics, the JD(U) is in the midst of a most difficult transition. For nearly two decades, the party revolved around Nitish; his governance model, carefully cultivated social coalition and image as a moderate administrator were its greatest assets. That success has created its own dilemma.

Despite commanding 85 MLAs and being an indispensable pillar of the NDA government in Bihar, the JD(U) has struggled to produce a second-rung leader with comparable appeal. Working president Sanjay K. Jha is an influential strategist, but purely at the organisational level. The JD(U)'s two deputy CMs—Vijay Choudhary, 69, and Bijendra Prasad Yadav, 79—too, are seen as experienced administrators. None of them, however, has the kind of statewide pull to hold together the diverse social coalition painstakingly assembled by Nitish. Thus it comes about that hopes are being pinned on a first-time, reluctant politician who's still learning the grammar of public life. ■